

Jenay Willis - BLMHE - Interview

Tobar: Thank you, again for agreeing to participate. Today is Wednesday, March 10, 2021. Can you please state your name and affiliation?

Willis: [00:00:11] My name is [Jenay Willis]. I am a doctoral student at the University of Pittsburgh. I am a former alum, TC alum, in the higher and post-secondary education program and also I was very involved with the Black Lives Matter in Higher Education group.

Tobar: Wonderful. Thank you. I just wanted to ask you about your background, your early life. Any family influence going back as far as your early education and anything that interested you about your early childhood that you would like to share? If you can tell me a little bit about that and you can begin anywhere you like.

Willis: [00:00:49] OK, so, in terms of education, correct? Ok, so what interested me in pursuing education as a career is Number 1, my grandmother, who only holds a fourth grade education and so she would also say, Janay, baby, go get your education because that's the one thing that the white man can't take from you. And so just having her as a role model kind of thing and just kind of instilling that knowledge in me to just keep persevering and going through. Then, also, my parents, as well. Both of my parents are college educated. Although I am – I'm considered first gen doc. Not first gen in terms of my undergraduate life, but first gen in terms of being a doctoral student within my immediate family.

[00:01:32] And so what's important to me is like, again, my parents instilling the importance of education in me and what it means to be a black woman, and specifically a black woman growing up in the South, and specifically in the black rural South. And what that means. And so there's often this deficit mindset that is looked – that the rural South is looked at. But my hope is to disrupt that deficit mindset and push back and change that mindset to there being a monolithic idea of what it means to be rural.

[00:02:07] Because oftentimes it's about, oh, there's a monolithic white narrative for what it means to be rural. But as a rural black student I'm here to like integrate and to provide space for black students who come from rural areas. And so they integrate into Black Lives Matter Higher Education because, again, the – what blackness means to exist across the diaspora and acknowledging that there's not a single of what it means to be black, but there are many perspectives and many ways to exist in our blackness, as black people, and just holding space for ourselves and living in our authentic blackness.

[00:02:48] And then how that ties into my education, even showing up as a black woman in my terms of like showing up in my authentic blackness and my personal world and in my professional world, I have to use code

switching in order to make it in these quote, unquote, make it in these spaces. Or to in a way assimilate all the forced assimilation to make it in these spaces or exist in these spaces. And by “spaces” I mean the predominantly white spaces that I earned and am obtaining my degrees, my post-secondary degrees.

Tobar: Wonderful. Thank you. Can you describe what your experience with your neighborhood and your community was like when you were growing up? Can you recall or remember any issues or moments that you and others in your neighborhood or your community were facing as you were growing up?

Willis: [00:03:40] Yeah, so, when I think about my childhood or recall my childhood, whirr very vividly is spending the summers with my grandmother and then just even when I was in grade school, K through 12, just going to my grandmother’s house after school and what that would look like. And then some of the struggles from that it’s like when I would get sick – because as a child, I was very sickly. I had a weak immune system. So the access to healthcare was a detriment in being in a rural area.

[00:04:09] And then also just being black. So it in a way heightens the disparity. And even in the age of Covid, now, I think about how little girls like me, or who, like me, might be facing similar things in life right now in terms of the disparities that are heightened. And again, it paints this picture of a deficit mindset.

[00:04:33] Like while there is limited access to healthcare in rural spaces, like having to drive maybe 30 minutes to an hour, or even more, to have access to the healthcare. And so what does that look like for black and brown people who come from rural spaces and want to integrate or want to pursue education. And then even in terms of education, to have to engage in rural flight in terms of – they’re like in a college desert, as [Dr. Amelia Dashe] talks about in her research. About there being a college desert and not having access to as many colleges within reach, like maybe a 15-mile radius or so, or even a 30-mile radius or so and what that looks like.

[00:05:14] And so I think the problems – or not the problems –

Tobar: And where was –

Willis: [00:05:20] Oh, I’m sorry.

Tobar: You go ahead. Because there’s a bit of a little delay with the Zoom. So you go ahead and finish that thought.

Willis: [00:05:32] Ok, thank you. And so what I would say is some of the colleges is in terms of education and in terms of healthcare. Access to post-secondary education and then access to healthcare for black people within the rural areas. But how do we change that near to of being able to have access to those places when we’re in dire need of those.

Tobar: Absolutely. And where was that rural area that you grew up.

Willis: [00:06:01] So, I grew up in a small town in the South. Again, the name of my town is Precise, Georgia, in Monroe County. I always have to differentiate because there's a Precise County and then there's a Precise, Georgia, and there's also a Monroe, Georgia and a Monroe County. But I am from Precise, Georgia, Monroe County.

Tobar: Thank you for clarifying that. Tell me a little bit about what it was like in that environment your earlier experiences in school and education in the classroom. What was that like?

Willis: [00:06:38] So, that's a great question because like my experiences in my school they kind of play into my scholarship as a researcher, currently. Within my K through 12 education, I was – the majority was white and then the minority was black and Mexican American students. And so for me, specifically within my high school education, if someone in your peer network or your support circle wasn't willing to advocate for you to go to school, whether it be a coach, a teacher, a mentor or your immediate or extended family, however you define or any sort, wasn't willing to serve as an advocate for you, then it almost seemed as if going to college was inaccessible, in way.

[00:07:27] And so I think about how within my own schooling, how when it was time to go off to college, the question for me was never am I going to college, but what college am I going to? And knowing that I come from a very educated family. And so but when I look around at my peers and I think about my peers who look like me, my black and brown peers, the rate at which we were going to college would be few and far in between but then my white peers or the great number of them went on to attend college, but also graduated college.

[00:07:59] And so, also, some of my black and brown peers who would go off to college, but the rate at which we would then complete it would dwindle as we continue to persist through those institutions. And really, again, having an advocate within the high school and what do those resources look like. But then when you get to college. To make it to and through college, what does that look like for rural black and brown students?

Tobar: Thank you for that. I'm going to ask perhaps that maybe we can switch off the video. Because there tends to be a little delay that you had mentioned with the Zoom. So I wanted to make sure that we capture as much as the audio as possible. Would you be able to switch off your camera?

Willis: [00:08:45] Yes, sounds good.

Tobar: And sorry to ask. So sorry about that.

Willis: [00:08:48] No, you're fine. Thank you.

Tobar: Thank you. And so I guess going back to that, you talked about how educated your family was. Can you describe a little bit about what that family environment was like growing up? What were your parents doing and how that inspired you and gave you that support system?

Willis: [00:09:07] Oh, yes, thank you. So growing up, my father – my mother and father didn't really engage in general, per se, however. However, my father was – in terms of the breadwinner, my father was seen as the breadwinner. But when it came to like what chores looked like around the house, whether it was washing dishes, washing clothes, both my mother and father and different other roles, there was not really an existence of a binary in terms of those gender roles.

[00:09:37] And then, also, growing up, my father, he's an entrepreneur. So my father, he's a mortician. He also sells insurance and he also has a lot of rental property, as well. So he always says that, oh, I serve both sides. I house you while you're living and then I help you when you transition and go into heaven. And so then my mother she is a nurse. She is a registered nurse and she has been so for I think 20-plus years, now.

[00:10:13] So she – and in that way, access to healthcare was beneficial in a way because of my mom. But had it not been for my mom, I don't know what access to healthcare would have been like. But it's still the fact that we still had to go quite a ways away to have access to that healthcare, whether it was 20 minutes to 40 minutes or so forth away, what that really looked like.

[00:10:41] And so I also grew up with siblings, as well, that were kind of influential of my education, too. Because all of my siblings – I have three older brothers. Each of them went to a historically black college or university. And so would just tell me how great it was and that experience and they kind of influenced me of like wanting to go to an HBCU. And so, although I didn't go to an HBCU, I did get the HBCU experience through enrolling in a summer program at Xavier University, in New Orleans. And so that kind of gave me like a feel of like what it feels like to be in an HBCU like over the course of like two or three months.

[00:11:21] And so, again, that allowed me to see the bigger picture of like how and where the education is and how important it is to instill in me, but then in the generations that come after me and leading that way. And so it's kind of a generational thing in terms of my parents being the first generation and then their kids, which is us, and then my future kids, hopefully, as well.

Tobar: That's wonderful. That summer program seems like it was a really rewarding experience. Can you tell me a little bit about that?

Willis: [00:11:54] Yeah, so I was – it was a part of the Excel Scholars Program at Xavier University. So what we did was it was – we stayed in the dorms, there, and we also enrolled in classes. So I think we took like two or three classes to get that college experience. So like I was enrolled in an English class and then also a math class. And then also we had an elective. Because through our elective we were able to do different activities such as like community service and stuff like that.

[00:12:26] Just get a feel of the campus of what it means to be like – and then because we were like this was the summer of my junior year. While I got this experience, there were like mentors like of the program that kind of like guided us throughout so we weren't alone on the campus or just by ourselves. Because, again, we were underage, if you will, kind of thing. And so just getting that experience allowed me to see like what it feels like to be in a very beautiful campus environment that like – like I'm seeing people who look like me.

[00:13:04] And so now like that I'm in a space where I don't see as many people that look like me, it sometimes makes me wonder what would it have been like had I done to an HBCU for my undergraduate or my graduate career.

Tobar: Tell me a little bit, then – I mean, it's so good that you were able to have that experience. Your journey to get that bachelor's degree for your undergraduate experience, where did you ultimately decide to go? What were your aspirations for a major or what disciplines where are interested in exploring? You can start anywhere regarding that.

Willis: [00:13:40] Yes. So in regards to my education and the rest of my undergraduate education. So, again, me wanting to go to an HBCU, my mind was set on Hampton University because I would have been a legacy because two of my brothers had gone to Hampton. But at the time I have very, very severe allergies, and so I was also HOPE eligible.

[00:14:06] And what HOPE is is HOPE is a scholarship for students who have a 3.0 grade average and above and can receive that scholarship within the state of Georgia. I think they do checkpoints. I think after 90 credit hours or so – I can't remember quite exactly. But then so because I was HOPE eligible, as well, my parents played a huge role in me choosing to stay in the state of Georgia and then allowing me to go whichever where – wherever I wanted to go for my graduate degree.

[00:14:36] And so because of that, I went to my mother's alma mater. And so it's a small public liberal arts university. And so there I entered – I actually started in a bridged summer program. And so the bridged summer program is exactly what it says it is. It helps you bridge into like – seamlessly like integrate into college life kind of thing. And so it kind of prepared me and then that way I was also able to enroll in two or three courses and I would take those courses like Monday through Friday, starting at 8:00 AM. And so that kind of helped me.

[00:15:17] And then I did when I entered the bridge program, I did enter as an undeclared major. Because I wasn't sure if I wanted to go the sociology route or whether I wanted to go the psychology route. But I know it was one of the two. And so that kind of helped – well, my mom – my mom – I had declared, actually, psychology. Then my mom said I think it would be wise for you to go undeclared.

[00:15:41] And so my mom kind of played a role in that in terms of helping me go undeclared. Because then I was able to then take classes in both psychology and sociology to kind of determine which route I want. Then I had a wonderful class with Dr. Stephanie McClure that let me know that I do want to take – I do want to have a major in sociology because of like the knowledge I was learning and gaining and just both from her and Dr. Sara Book Dow, just helped me be who I am today and it kind of plays a role into my research, as well.

[00:16:13] I see how like what I learned in undergrad is now playing into – it's like building upon the knowledge that I've already gained.

Tobar: That's wonderful. Thank you so much. Can you please tell me again what institution was it that you went for your undergrad? It may have been cut off by the video recording.

Willis: [00:16:31] OK, I'm sorry. Yeah, I went to the Georgia State public liberal arts university, Georgia College and State University. Hello? I'm sorry. It switched to my air pods. Can you hear me now?

Tobar: Yes, I can, yes.

Willis: [00:16:56] Yeah, OK, I'm sorry. It had switched to my air pods for some odd reason. I'm sorry.

Tobar: No, no worries in the least. If you want to tell me the name of the university we can take it up from where we left off if that's all right.

Willis: [00:17:10] OK, yeah. so the name of the university for my undergraduate institution is Georgia College and State University in Millersville, Georgia. It's the state's public liberal arts university.

Tobar: Wonderful. And it seems like you had such a rewarding experience while you were there. And so tell me a little bit about that experience, that journey, and what ultimately led you to consider pursuing graduate studies up until when you arrived at TC.

Willis: [00:17:41] OK. So I was a very active student leader on the campus. And so within that one particular role that kind of helps me like think about who I want to become and who I am becoming was working under leadership of Dr. Veronica Womack, who is my mentor, even today. And just like seeing a black woman who looks like me and doing the work of

the institution – and by the work of the institution I mean like while people have missions, it's often it's just written. But to carry out the actions is another thing. And I always saw her beautifully embody how she walked the walk and also talked the talk in doing the work in terms of truly being equity-driven, justice driven, social justice oriented, and just creating space for students of color and all students, really.

[00:18:38] And just showing us that we can be the change that we want to see. And just thinking about the conversations I had with her and have with her, today, and what that continues to instill in me about the importance of education and especially rural education. Because just like – just like I studied rural research, she does, as well. And so she was kind of like in a way like one of my dissertation coach says. She was a possibility model for me.

[00:19:07] A possibility model in terms of like I see her doing this, so then that lets me know that I, too, can do this work. So just serving in that role as a diversity peer educator under her leadership and guidance kind of helped me like steer me in the direction. Like I want to do this work. And I believe this work is my life's calling. And so when I went on to what made me pursue graduate education was when I – I knew I wanted to pursue graduate education.

[00:19:36] And so – but I took a gap year. And so within that gap year it let me really know. I served in AmeriCorps for a year and I was working in a charter school with black and brown students that let me know like these students are not seeing the colleges – and this was – I just the nuance that exists across urban and rural spaces in terms of black and brown students being able to see and have access to these schools. And just being able to see it and walking through the tours and stuff how much that can be the change in order for them to see that change but then also to walk into that change.

[00:20:18] Into what does it mean for us as black and brown students to have access to institutions if we don't see it, first? And I think envisioning it – in order to envision it, first, I think you have to like physically be able to see it, as well, and the importance of what that means. And so that really let me know that I think that higher education, specifically, is for me to be a face, another rural black face, or rural black student to let people from my hometown and other rural areas like let them know that they can be in this space and occupy this space and we so much deserve to.

[00:20:54] So that brings me to today where I am pursuing my doctoral degree in terms of truly earning this degree so that I can have a seat at a table or earn a seat at the table or make myself a seat at the table within my hometown. Because often, again, going back to assimilation, I have to prove a lot that through these degrees I do deserve to be heard. I do deserve to disrupt the notion of rurality equating to whiteness and challenging what that means because black and brown voices do matter and I think a lot of times that often goes under heard. And so I think –

[00:21:29] Also, another part that plays in is my – I’m very young and I understand. I know that sometimes that’s not well-received in terms of, oh, like, for example, someone might say, oh, she’s not lived much life so she doesn’t know. But I think that I have lived plenty of life, even with my education career, to know what I am talking about and to know what – because this is not only me writing about it, this is my lived experiences in doing this rural black research.

[00:21:58] So I think that’s important. It has played a vital role in my education in terms of my mentor, but then also in terms of the people I’ve met along the way who have instilled in me like this is the work that is needed and why it’s needed. It reminds me of TC and when I was writing my statement. I remember coming to the open house and they were just saying you should definitely mention in your statement why TC and why now.

[00:22:23] And so why now, even today, and when I was pursuing my master’s at TC, is because why now is because the time is now. Because I am not doing this degree for me but I’m thinking about those who come behind me. And so the future matters. And so in doing that it lets me know that other rural black students who wish to fall in my footsteps, I’ve paved the way for them. And so I can just – and through my paving the way for them, this lets them know that they, too, can become doctor.

Tobar: Thank you so much. Janay, would it be all right for you to repeat your last sentence just one more time for the video recording.

Willis: [00:23:20] Yes. So, I think it’s very important in terms of going back to that being able to see why representation matters. And so I say that to say that while I’m obtaining and working towards earning my doctoral degree, it’s not just being earned with me. I’m thinking about all the people that I’m bringing along the way in terms of my ancestors, in terms of my family, in terms of my entire support system. But most importantly for the students or for the black and brown kids who will come behind me and what that means for those students. And me helping pave the way.

[00:23:56] And I know that my predecessors have also paved the way and then also but I’m thinking about currently in the climate that we’re in right now with all that is going on in the world in terms of being in multiple pandemics, what that means in terms of continuing to persist. And so just truly know that I’m doing this work for those who come behind me is what’s most important in me pursuing my doctoral degree.

Tobar: That’s wonderful. Thank you for sharing that. Tell me a little bit about what compelled you to apply for the higher and post-secondary education program at TC. How many other schools were you considering and tell me a little bit about what happened on your way to finally deciding on Teacher’s College being your destination for your master’s program.

Willis: [00:24:47] Thank you. So I think for me because I was in New Jersey at the time when I decided to apply to graduate school. And so I did apply to two or three programs and I got into both. And so – but one of them I know was fully online. And I didn't know at first that it was because the website said otherwise. But then when I received the email I was like, oh. And then that goes back to even being like maybe a first generation master's or doctoral student and this knowledge was not beknown to me.

[00:25:34] And so kind of just understanding like I know how I best operate in the classroom and so I think choosing between TC and the other program was a very seamless process for me because I was like, well, I don't want to do – I don't operate very well in an online environment. I might even – I might be seen as a number and not seen as a student. And my teachers and professors not really knowing me. And so in that way TC was the first, second and third choice.

[00:26:02] And also just the open house that I went to when I get to meet faculty. I got to meet students. And just like what I felt – like the ambiance the room and just the energy of the room let me know that this is the place for me. And then I also will never forget during the open house I heard Dr. Yolanda Sealey-Ruiz speak. And when I saw a beautiful black woman speak and just be very passionate in what she was saying, but then also for her to like come and meet like – meet me and speak with me and pour into me the way she did let me know that, yes, TC has chosen me, but I've also chosen them in return.

Tobar: That's wonderful. So tell me about that period of time transitioning after that gap year and then coming from New Jersey and then making that decision to come to TC until you finally came to TC. Tell me about what that experience was like.

Willis: [00:27:08] So my experience in my charter school, it was – in one word I think it was like – that's a great question. I'm trying to see how – because it was a beautiful experience. But I don't want to – it was beautiful, but it was also in some ways very taxing because I was away from home for the first time for a long time. And so what does that look like for me?

[00:27:37] Well, I was also a ways away from home, I also had a piece of home with me in that my sorority sister she and I were roommates. So that kind of helped me transition, in a way. But in terms of like being in that environment it was a very – it was a very – a nice environment to be in because in the school I worked in I constantly saw black and brown faces that looked like me and I constantly saw black and brown children who looked like me. And just being able to pour into them and then just service them kind of like tutor, teacher, mentor kind of thing.

[00:28:17] And then, also, with them, seeing – when I did get accepted to TC, just letting them know like I also felt like in a way a possibility model for them in that like, oh, Miss Willis is doing this, so then I can do this kind of thing. So just, again, acknowledging the nuances across rural and

urban spaces and what that means. And so I think what I see in research oftentimes is that rural and urban spaces are tied against each other when the reality they're more similar than they are different.

[00:28:49] And I think that's important because in that space that I was when I was in Newark, New Jersey, I was like really able to see a snapshot of how my rural life in a way is played into the urban school setting, as well. And so that kind of led me to my path within higher education specifically because I wanted to make sure that black and brown voices were uplifted. But I also wanted to be a reason why my presence and my representation matters in knowing that I'm adding to the number of black women – black people, but black women, specifically – who hold and obtain terminal degrees and even more specific doctoral degrees.

Tobar: Wonderful. So once you were at TC, that we did you identity affect your day-to-day experience once you were a student at TC? Did you ever feel that it was a marginalized identity?

Willis: [00:30:03] So I think that – and I say multiple identities. I think about all of my identities, I don't think about a single identity. And so I think about my being black, my being a woman and my being rural. And so I think about all of those identities together because for me it's about how those identities meet at the intersection. And so in terms of being at TC, I saw those – I saw my identities interplay in terms of how I navigate through spaces how I was able to – how I showed up.

[00:30:43] And so I feel like I was able to in certain spaces show up as my authentic black self without the code switching piece, which I feel like code switching is used as a survival tool and it is used as a survival tool. And also at the same time I think what really helped me is when I met [Ty. Ty McNamey]. Because he also identified as rural. He started the Rural Student Group, which was like a beautiful experience for me because Number 1 I had never been introduced into a group like this, before.

[00:31:17] But also because I'm like coming from a place of like where I'm from. Not that many know about rural places or it's so small that it's never thought about and it just opened me up into this new world and that we are being talked about in a positive manner, that. We're not this monolith of what it means to exist and live in a rural space. And so just seeing Ty and allowing to like kind of like form a mentorship with him as my mentor kind of helped me navigate that space.

[00:31:47] And then, also, with the professors, as well, seeing me and all of my identities and not just one of my identities. Specifically Dr. Corbin Campbell and Dr. Noah Drezner seeing me in all of my identities and understanding that they see me as human and they don't see me as this robot. It really helped me navigate that space, as well.

[00:32:08] And I remember one like pivotal moment in my life. It was actually when I was in my master's at TC, when I lost my grandmother.

And I just remember seeing Ty and Dr. Drezner both like seeing me at the table outside of Zankel and just embracing me and seeing me in that moment. Because, again, that's who I'm doing this degree for is in my grandmother's honor. But also for those who come behind me. And I just think about how important the tool of education is in terms of how I show up and I bring all of me into the spaces that I occupy.

Tobar: Thank you for sharing that. And I guess it's a good segue into this other question, but it's great that you were able to find those systems of support within the program – the higher and post-secondary education program. Do you ever feel that your race affected your own classroom experience at TV? And did it ever feel isolating? I know that able to talk about it. It's not just a single identity. They're intersectional. But in this particular case, I'm interested in exploring whether you ever felt that your race, specific, ever felt isolating while you were at TC?

Willis: [00:33:16] I think within my experience and being black, I didn't see it as isolating because, again, I was very involved with Black Lives Matter in higher and post-secondary education. And I think that was a very integral part, too, and being a co-facilitator of Black Lives Matter in higher education. And so I think having that group helped me navigate that space was very great. But then also having colleagues who look like me navigate the space while I was in TC.

[00:33:51] But in terms of the classroom, I wouldn't say that I had – I would say that I had challenging conversations and tough conversations that need to be had, but those conversations needed to be had in order to foster growth. But in terms of answering the question in terms of it being like I don't feel seen or I don't like – in terms of like navigating, I always felt seen by my professors.

[00:34:18] I always – and even if there was a tough conversation and my professor could see that clearly I was unsettled, they would always be willing to talk to me, whether it was like right after the class or whether it was meeting in office hours. So I felt like in that way my black – my identity as a black woman was very seen and it wasn't negated when it played a vital role in terms of the conversations that were fostered in terms of occupying spaces in higher education within a predominantly white institution.

Tobar: Thank you. Do you believe that the faculty and students at TC values diversity? Why or why not? And did they provide any support and what kind. I feel like you answered a bit of this question, already. But just in case there were some other items that would be to bring up that weren't mentioned before, feel free.

Willis: [00:35:12] Thank you. I think I struggle with the term of diversity sometimes. Because I think it's a buzz word. It's a buzz of the time. And so I think over time it does transform. And so a word that I more so resonate with is equity. And so I think that my professors were very much

equitable in terms of how they engaged with students and how they – in terms of like really like getting to know the students, getting to understand the student kind of thing.

[00:35:51] I think that we were all seen through an equitable lens and that no one received one treatment better than the other. Even when I was doing my application process for my doctoral, for applying to Ph.D. program, it was a very equitable process in terms of like, OK, so who will I ask to serve as a reference? And so even in that – I know that me and another colleague were also going through the same experiences.

[00:36:24] And so but we both had the same professor serve as our references and in that way it wasn't a competition or anything. They both saw us as students and saw us as the whole student. And so I think for them to be able to see us both – of course, we were with two different people. At the same time, they recognized that we have different strengths. And just being able to pour into our strengths in those ways, whether it be in the classroom or whether it be in the doctoral application process.

Tobar: Great. What barriers do you believe exist that prevent TC in any way from leveraging difference and being inclusive of all students, if at all?

Willis: [00:37:09] Barriers. I think for me a barrier that might have existed is in terms of the scholarships and not being made aware of the scholarships going in. Because I know that scholarships are available, and sometimes it feels like they can be whispered in a way to help – because most students – and this is not just HIPSE specific. But in terms of Teacher's College when entering those programs – and I have colleagues, too, now, who are paying for their degree. And so what does that support look like if we can receive support for obtaining the degree in terms of scholarship, in terms of graduate assistantships, maybe.

[00:38:07] And so what does that truly look like? And so I think that goes back to like socioeconomic status, or like what do I identify as. And I identify as middle class. However, again, coming back to that first generation piece, as a graduate student, and what that looks like for me. So I think it was – I think about, now, I think about [Dr. Yusof's] Community Culture [World] and how those kind of play into who I am even today.

[00:38:38] But while at TC I think that it would have been beneficial for me I saw or had someone to diverge how those identities of like whether it's linguistic capital, whether it's social capital or whether it's aspirational capital. What those things look like for me and how they would have helped me be better successful while enrolled at TC.

Tobar: Broadly speaking, how do you believe your race affected your own ability to succeed at TC, if at all?

Willis: [00:39:21] I'm sorry can you repeat the question?

Tobar: Sure. Broadly speaking, how do you believe your race affected your own ability to succeed at TC, if at all?

Willis: [00:39:32] How did my race affect my ability to succeed? I don't think that it affected by ability to succeed. I think if anything it served as an asset in my ability to succeed. And I say that to that because I saw, again, mentors who looked like me and being able to work with mentors who look like me, personally, I was able to work in Dr. Janice Robinson's office. And so, again, having a mentor for my undergrad who I saw as a possibility model.

[00:40:13] But then also seeing Dr. Janice Robinson also as a possibility model for me. And also with her being a part of the Higher and Post-Secondary Education Faculty also served, and the many hats that she wears. So I was able to see how being in the roles that she is in, how that is a possibility for me in terms of who I want to be and become. So I say that because I think that my being black and then also knowing her as a black woman how that helped me as an individual see that I can be and I can become what I hope to be.

[00:41:01] And so also just really emphasizing the importance of it serving as an asset, rather than it serving as a detriment. Because, also, the community that I surrounded myself with while at TC was I would say that I had a lot of black and brown scholars that I was in quite a bit of conversation with. But I was also in conversations with my white peers, as well.

[00:41:30] And so being able to exist and what do the nuances look across me existing in both of those worlds. And then also it goes back to that piece about being able to live in my authentic blackness and my personal world and not having to code switch. And then my professional world, using code switching as a survival tool and also it's about being able to be in conversation with a diverse array of people and not just one single – and, again, there's no one – there's not a monolithic idea of what the human race is.

[00:42:01] There's much diversity that exists across the human race. But just the nuances of being able to – like even I think now of how my education at TC played a pivotal role in how I show up today in terms of like how I identify as rural, versus country. Or the nuances that exist across those in terms of also being black and also acknowledging the beauty of the blackness across the African diaspora.

[00:42:26] And then the conversation I was able to have with peers who are – even my best friend I met at TC. She is Nigerian American and just understanding that while there may be nuances across our stories, there are also difference in how we show up and stuff. And they help us understand who we are as people, but also acknowledging that there are nuances in who we are.

Tobar: Thank you for that. I think it's a great time to transition to thinking about your involvement with BLMHE. Can you recall how you felt about being involved with them initially and how it affected you?

Willis: [00:43:07] Yes. So I really appreciated that I was invited to be a part of BLMHE – Black Lives Matter Higher Education. And so I think the invitation for me was like a way of like I feel like I'm being embraced. I feel like this is a warm welcome. And especially for me, again, I draw on this identity a lot. And being from the South, from the rural South, from a very small place.

[00:43:34] And so going into TC like how do I find my place, or how do I fit in here? Or what do my affinity groups look like? How do my identities play into how I show up in these places? And I think Black Lives Matter Higher Education really helped me in terms of like kind of taking me in a way – inviting me, number one. But then in a way taking me under their wing and saying that we're family kind of thing. And then also when I became a co-facilitator, it allowed me to see again how doing the activist work is really – is a continual process.

[00:44:18] And so I just think about how Black Lives Matter Higher Education really served as like a pivotal moment for me in terms of me finding an affinity group that I best identify with. Then me also finding the Rural Student Group and being able to have both of those identities show up in who I am as a person. But specifically, as you mentioned Black Lives Matter Higher Education I think about being overseen by two white professors.

[00:44:48] And while it's overseen by two white professors, the two white professors are very much co-conspirators. So we as the group – as a student group, me and the black students who were in the group, we proposed ideas and made suggestions and then we kind of like discussed it with our mentors of the group, if you will. It was them allowing us to do the heavy lifting and – well, not the heavy lifting.

[00:45:24] But them allowing us to integrate our voices into what we wanted to do with the group and them seeing our vision and then allowing us to carry out that vision, while also in a way serving as a guidance in terms of who we are. And just truly being the co-conspirator to stand beside us and not in front of us, if you will. I believe that's what's important in terms of being a co-conspirator. It's someone who doesn't look down upon you, but someone who stands beside you and we are all seen as equals in doing this work.

Tobar: Could you describe what your vision of activism was before becoming involved with BLMHE? And how that vision and your role within that different vision of activism has changed since then?

Willis: [00:46:15] I think my true activism was activated when I began as an undergrad. And so I think doing the work I did as a diversity peer educator

kind of transpired and carried with me into my work at TC. I think that my involvement in terms of like running different or having different presentations, going into residence halls and going into classrooms and teaching about the knowledge that needs to be shared in terms of what it truly means to be in a diverse, inclusive and equitable environment. And being able to not only like have the vision written, but seeing and walking in that vision.

[00:47:13] And so for me that was actually being involved on campus. Being a student leader and then carrying those same tools, those transferrable skills into my work at TC. So I think the groundbreaking happened within my undergraduate career, but then it carried with me into TC in how I show up in terms of being involved with Black Lives Matter Higher Education and being able to, again, bring in all of my identities and all the parts of me as a black woman from the South, from the rural South, and truly like understanding like, wow, while it is a culture shock for me going from a very small town – even my college town was a small town. To now like the biggest city in the universe – I mean, not universe. The biggest city in the United States, what does that look like for me?

[00:48:11] And I think that I definitely would say Black Lives Matter Higher Education and Dr. Noah Drezner and Dr. Corbin Campbell played a huge role in that in terms of my education while there at TC.

Tobar: Can you tell me a little bit about that time period and what that was like being involved as a co-facilitator in regards to coming up with discussions and the work that was involved with being in BLMHE as student and how that helped your own development as an academic or higher education practitioner.

Willis: [00:48:48] Yes. So as a co-facilitator, it helped my role as a scholar practitioner, number 1, because it's all about putting – like what I learned in the classroom I'm now seeing it be carried out through practice. And so I think what helped was we often would – we would often meet and have meetings like just have check-ins, like how's everyone doing? Then it's also about doing the actual – the groundbreaking work of, OK, let's put what we're talking about into action.

[00:49:23] So we would do welcome sessions. We would do sessions and we would get invited – similar to my undergraduate – get invited to speak to different organizations, and even do the conference. Participate in the conference at TC. I can't recall the name right now. But just participating in that conference and what it looks like. Just to be truly engaged in the work.

[00:49:53] Because I believe it's one thing that to say you're doing the work. But then it's another thing to put it into action. And so in doing the work that we did – and I think it's still being continued, today, I think is important that as an organization our voices need to be heard as black scholars. And, again, acknowledging the beauty that exists across the

African diaspora and the black diaspora. And knowing that there's not a single voice of what it means to be black, but there is a beauty in the many voices and experiences that contribute to blackness.

[00:50:37] And so just continuing that work. Even now, I see the work and how it shows up in my research. And I think that's why I say that I think being a part of BLMHE was a very pivotal experience for me. Because number 1, because I was embraced. And then also at the same time it helped me see where I wanted my research agenda to go, along with being involved with the Rural Student Group, and how much that truly means – meant to me, then, but how much it means now in my work and how I show up as a scholar practitioner, even now.

Tobar: What goal did you have in mind to accomplish while you were at TC and how does a degree from Teacher's College – how did that ultimately help you on your journey?

Willis: [00:51:28] I think my ultimate goal while there was of course like I'm here with the end goal in mind and that's to obtain my degree. And so at the same time while there my – what I do while in this environment impacts my career, long term, and the transferrable skills that I'm able to take with me back home to my rural community and rural areas alike.

[00:51:58] Then, also, thinking about how much it meant to me to be in the different offices that I was a part of while there. So, for example, in my graduate assistantship, I oversaw different affinity groups while I was at the New York Institute of Technology. And so what that meant for me as a graduate assistant kind of plays into my being scholar practitioner because I'm able to wear many hats.

[00:52:32] And, also, exist and speak to different audiences in terms of how I integrate into spaces. But also how I show up in these spaces and I'm also able to get – like I've been saying throughout the interview, is that how I'm able to thread all of my identities across these spaces, and not just exist with a single identity.

[00:52:54] And so I think what really was a grand moment for me was being able to work in the office with Dr. Janice Robinson because it allowed me to truly see the work that I want to do in my life work, and the work that I've been called to do. And I think also a lot of times we don't talk about this often, but being in higher education sometimes is a thankless job. Although it can be a thankless job, it's about continuing the work and continuing – because like I said, activism work never stops. It's a continual process. Because if we're going to be in this work, we have to continue to keep up the fight of the good trouble, as Congressman John Lewis would always say.

[00:53:48] So it's about doing the work of good trouble, but also centering ourselves in terms of our identities, in terms of me being black, rural and a

woman and how that shows up into the spaces that I occupy and in the spaces that I hope to occupy in rooms that I have yet to enter.

Tobar: Thank you for that. Can you describe what you think are your strengths and talents and how you use them to achieve your goals?

Willis: [00:54:32] I think that my strength that I often draw upon is flexibility. Because there's beauty in flexibility. But then also my consistency in terms of like my persistence even in the face of adversity. And so I draw on those. I feel like I have a number of strengths but I will draw on those two specifically because I think in terms of flexibility I think that when doing the work, when working in a higher education institution or when doing activist work, flexibility – it's not going to always go – like we can plan and plan all day. And so sometimes it's not going to always go as planned.

[00:55:16] And so sometimes that's where the flexibility comes in and being able to whether it's reschedule or reframe situations in terms of like situations in terms of like presentations, in terms of conversations, in terms of like just doing the work and continuing to persist in spite of like what is faced. And I say what is faced in terms of society. Because all the time – that's what I really appreciate about my education at TC is that when things would happen within society – in all aspects, not just one aspect.

[00:55:54] Not just the race issue. Not just the ability issue but in all aspects in terms of race, gender, sexuality and a plethora of identities. How they were addressed right there on the spot in terms of, OK – and I really appreciate when – again, the police brutality was happening against black bodies and it's still happening today, how that was brought into the fold. But it was not just one identity seeing, but it was about being black, being a woman, being a man or being non-gender conforming. And that were we able to see all of those identities and not just a single identity again.

[00:56:38] And so I think it's just truly transformative work and being able to be flexible in terms of those conversations. And say like, in the classroom, in terms of, OK, we might have this plan for the day, however, this has happened in society, so we need to have those tough conversations right now. And just pushing – and it goes back to what you mentioned earlier about feeling like being in the margins.

[00:57:04] And that's why I say I didn't – I felt like I was – when I was – in my experience at TC, I may have existed because my identities I might have existed in the margins, of the margins, however, I didn't feel that way because I had professors who saw me. And they saw me as whole and all of my identities and how I was able to show up and engage in their courses both in the classroom and during the office hours.

[00:57:31] And then even with the work of Black Lives Matter Higher Education, doing those and just truly being flexible in terms of like, OK, I want to show that I truly am supporting and it's genuine support, too. Because I'm a really good reader of energy and so I appreciate the genuine

support while there in terms of my identity and my involvement with Black Lives Matter in Higher Education and how that plays into who I am today.

[00:57:55] And then the persistent piece I think is important. I think because, again, things happen often within our lives, whether personal, professional and being the wide array of when things happen in society. Because I think it's sometimes it's disheartening to see when things happen in our communities – specifically black and brown communities. But to be able to have those conversations and to then to even persist in spite of, it just lets us know that the work is continuing to be done and it's just not like, "Oh, we're having this conversation and that's the end of it.

[00:58:34] That's never – I never felt that way. And so the fact that we have the conversation and then the work continues and we're trying to undo the harm that has been caused, here, in terms of like how black – specifically how black women are seen and occupying these spaces and what it means. And even occupying the academy and that we continue to do this work in spite of these institutions not being built with us in mind.

Tobar: And how does working in BLMHE efforts changed the way you engage in activism and your local community?

Willis: I'm sorry, can you repeat the question?

Tobar: Sure. How has working in BLMHE efforts changed the way you engage in activism and your local community?

Willis: [00:59:30] I think in terms of my local community, it has – and when I define community, I think about my professional community in terms of me as a researcher in the spaces that I occupy and my comfort zone. And I think even this year, I think BLMHE played a role – or Black Lives Matter Higher Education played a role in terms of how I was able to occupy the spaces that I do in terms of being able to show up how I show up when I present at, again, my home comfort.

[01:00:16] And I think my home conference is ASH, Association
[01:00:18] Education. And that is becoming my conference home, if you will. And so just the way that I can present myself and then just the knowledge gained from being involved while at TC and Black Lives Matter Higher Education using those tools to then show up in these spaces and then to be – to just talk without nerves. Because I know that sometimes it can be anxiety-driven to have these conversations.

[01:00:46] And so just doing that work and being a co-facilitator while at – during my time at TC, kind of helped prepare me for where I stand today. And also being at TC and part of Black Lives Matter Higher Education makes me thinking the hard work that my ancestors did for me to even occupy such a space in a predominantly white institution. And so just continuing to do that work now and how it's showing up in my

community, today, is just, again, continue to have those tough conversations.

[01:01:16] To dig deep and to like, “OK, this grassroots work needs to be done then it has to be done. Because where one or two are gathered, that’s where change can be fostered. Sometimes you don’t always have an army in doing this work. And I think that that’s the important thing is that if you have one or two people and the one or two people are being seen as, “Oh, this is great work being done, here, then I also want to join. And so the one or two people starting may not have an army, but it can eventually become an army in terms of we want to this work to be done and we want it to be done well.

[01:01:52] And sometimes that takes time. And I think what matters is quality and not quantity and doing the work of good trouble

Tobar: Thank you for that. What are your thoughts on politics in this continued fight against racial inequality and higher education?

Willis: [01:02:15] I’m sorry, it was a little –

Tobar: Choppy?

Willis: [01:02:19] Yes.

Tobar: I’ll repeat it again, for sure. No worries. What are your thoughts on how student movements continue to inform and influence culture and politics [audio breaks up]?

Willis: [01:02:39] I’m so sorry. Is it possible for you to type it in the chat because it broke up again. I apologize.

Tobar: Sure thing. No, no worries in the least. Let me type that up. But in the meantime I’ll repeat it one more time. What are your thoughts on how student movements continue to inform and influence culture and politics as we [audio breaks up]?

Willis: I’m sorry. The ending was chopping up. What is the – I’m going to look for the chat. I’m sorry. It was chopping up again. I apologize. My Wi-Fi is not the greatest. What are your thoughts on how student movements continue to inform and influence culture and politics as we continue to fight racial inequality in higher education?

[01:03:53] I think that, 1) Students are why institutions exist, first and foremost. Because without students there would be no institutions. And so I think that in terms of the movements that are going on, I think – especially right now what’s going on. I think that the student movements matter business we need the voices of future generations who are those – who will be in positions that will be leading our future to influence and continue to aspire against racial inequality and higher education.

[01:04:35] Because I think of even right now of just in my time at Pitt and the different groups on campus, even meeting virtually how these conversations are still being had. And so as student – and I think the time is now, as well. Because as I am still a student, and have the identity of a student, this is when I think a bulk of the groundbreaking work happens in terms of before I transition and become faculty or staff.

[01:05:11] And so I think that the student movement will continue to inform and influence what is happening in our world and in our society in terms of the students being the change that are fostering the groundbreaking change or the pivotal change. Not performative change because sometimes change happens and it can be very performative. I want to note that.

[01:05:40] But not being performative because once performative it's almost seen as robotic. And so in doing this work, to make it truly transformational, it's as vital that it be good work, but necessary trouble and good work at the same time.

[01:06:03] And so that may look very different in many ways. However, for me, I think it looks like – and my being a student and being involved within what I'm involved with as a doctoral student, I think that means me being willing, as I am, now, just continue to be willing to speak up and speak out against when something is – when there's wrongdoing.

[01:06:32] And just continuing to be able to have those tough conversations, even when – when people want to sweep them under the rug. And so rather than sweep them under the rug I think it's important that we push the agenda. And, again – and that goes back to the theme of what I see as the theme of the margin of the margins. If we want to continue to be seen and not invalidated, then continue to provide these places for ourselves when no one else is going to provide them for us.

[01:07:02] And so these movements are pivotal and vital because we, as students, are the voices that foster the change. And so as a black student and as a rural black student, I think that there is no better time than now because of the wake of where we are in our country and, again, of multiple pandemics happening, and what it means especially you spoke to racial inequality, what it means when black bodies are constantly policed.

[01:07:30] What does it mean when black bodies are constantly seen as a threat to society. And so I say that to say that students' voices, particularly in my identities, black student voice and black women's voices especially matter in this work if we're going to continue to make transformational change and continue to do this work of activism. That is continual.

Tobar: Thank you, Janay. At the end of the day, how would you characterize the impact that all this work has had in your own life and in your own thinking?

Willis: [01:08:10] In my own life, again, I think I go back to where my identities meet at the intersection in terms of being rural, black and a woman, and how it's my lived experiences that I bring with me to this work. And I think that is truly transformational when – however I bring it to this work that I do it in a way that's genuine. I do it in a way that's me living in my authenticity. And I also do it in a way that sets up a pathway – or paves a pathway for those who come behind me.

[01:08:47] Because I think that, again, in doing this work, in terms of the truly activist work, it's about being able to walk the walk and talk the talk. And about those coexisting and in terms of them coexisting make sure that whenever I'm talking that it's the same and it mirrors what I'm walking. It's not me saying – talking in one way and then polar opposite of the walking or talking but how those two co-exist and they mirror each other in terms of this work and my work now.

[01:09:27] And I even think about the present study that I'm working on now in terms of the students I'm studying with. And I say with because I am studying with rural black students, which I also identify as. And so I think for me to continue to integrate the voices of rural black students and black students across the diaspora, the African diaspora, it's important that I persist. It's important that also while persisting that I do get my rest.

[01:09:55] Because I think what happens a lot is we do this work, but we don't allow our bodies to rest. And in order to continue this work, we must respond to our body and respond to what we need in order to get the work done and in order to continually foster this change for those who hope to come behind us and be the trailblazers for those students.

Tobar: Thank you, Janay. I think we're done. do you have any final words you want to add before we wrap up?

Willis: [01:10:30] I think that was all. Thank you so much, Cynthia.

Tobar: Thank you so much, Janay, for taking time to speak with me, today. Hopefully, your video will work, again. Thank you, again.

[End of recording 01:10:45]